THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

AMONG the papers, letters, etc.,* presented to the Library by Mrs. Thomas Foljambe Burgess of Scarsdale, New York, are two series of letters from the Near East, written during the years 1827–1855, by the brothers Charles and Edward Burgess, sons of the English banker, economist, and editor, Henry Burgess. These letters afford as connected a history of the adventures and fortunes of Occidentals in the Orient as any "narrative of travel and description" that has been published, while the pen of the trained novelist could make of the story as rich and warm and fascinating a novel as has been written on such a theme. But aside from their interest as human documents and their possible inspiration for the novelist, the letters, written during that period when Turkey became the "sick man of Europe," when Russia was whittling Persia down to her present boundaries, when England was establishing and consolidating her whole position in India and Asia Minor, acquire added value by affording unexpected glimpses into the play and counter-play of the Great Powers, the initiation and prosecution of policies which, at this very moment, are coloring events in Egypt, the western Mediterranean, and the Middle East.

From 1826 to 1828 the closing acts of the drama of Greek independence from Turkey were being played to their stirring conclusion. The famous English diplomat, Stratford Canning, was minister to the Porte; those perennial foes, England, Russia, and France, were banded together in a crusade to free the Christian Greeks; an allied squadron had "blundered" into Navarino bay in 1827 and destroyed the Turkish fleet. In Persia the grandiose schemes of the crown prince, Abbas Mirza, to recover territories lost to Russia was ending in the utter rout of the Persians, the capture of Tabriz by the Russians, and the humiliating Treaty of Turkomanchai, concluded just in time to enable the Czar to declare formal war on Turkey. The British Minister to the Shah, Sir John Macdonald, was striving mightily to throw up any sort of bulwark against a Russian threat to India, and British money, munitions, and drill sergeants for the Persian army (and the concomitant of British manufactured products) were beginning to trickle into the country in ever-increasing volume.

Against this background, Charles Henry Burgess, eldest son of Henry and Frances (Ridsdale) Burgess, went out to Persia at the instance of a Persian merchant, Sadik Bey (later ennobled by the Shah as Syeed Khan) in 1827, at

* See a note, "Gift of Anglo-Persian papers," by Miss Mabel C. Weaks in the *Bulletin*, v. 43, p. 484, June, 1939; without her careful and painstaking arranging and cataloguing of the gift by Mrs. Burgess, this edition of the Persian letters would have been impossible.

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